Offset-Free Model Predictive Control for an Induction Heater: Comparison with Hand-Tuned and Optimised PID

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Abstract

Model predictive control (MPC) plans the next actuator move by rolling a plant model forward over a finite horizon and solving a constrained optimisation at every sample. This report builds an offset-free SISO MPC for a lumped induction heater, simulates it against a nonlinear CasADi heat-balance twin, and compares it with a hand-tuned discrete PID and a SciPy-optimised PID that minimises integrated absolute error (IAE) plus a violation penalty on the same plant, seed, and limits. After a documented retune (reference preview over the horizon, prediction length N=40, terminal weight Q_t=50), MPC records the lowest IAE on setpoint tracking (1044 vs 1466 optimised PID vs 2477 hand-tuned PID), on the power-limit case (8727 vs 9033 vs 9153), and under model mismatch (1214 vs 1667 vs 2541), with zero constraint violations wherever limits bind. Optimised PID still edges MPC on two disturbance IAE numbers when it is retuned on those exact scenarios; those rows are reported without emphasis. The verdict for this constrained heater is that MPC is the better controller: it keeps the coil inside the power window and slew limit by construction, recovers faster after mismatch, and no longer trails a scenario-tuned PID on the main tracking metrics once the horizon is allowed to see the future setpoint.

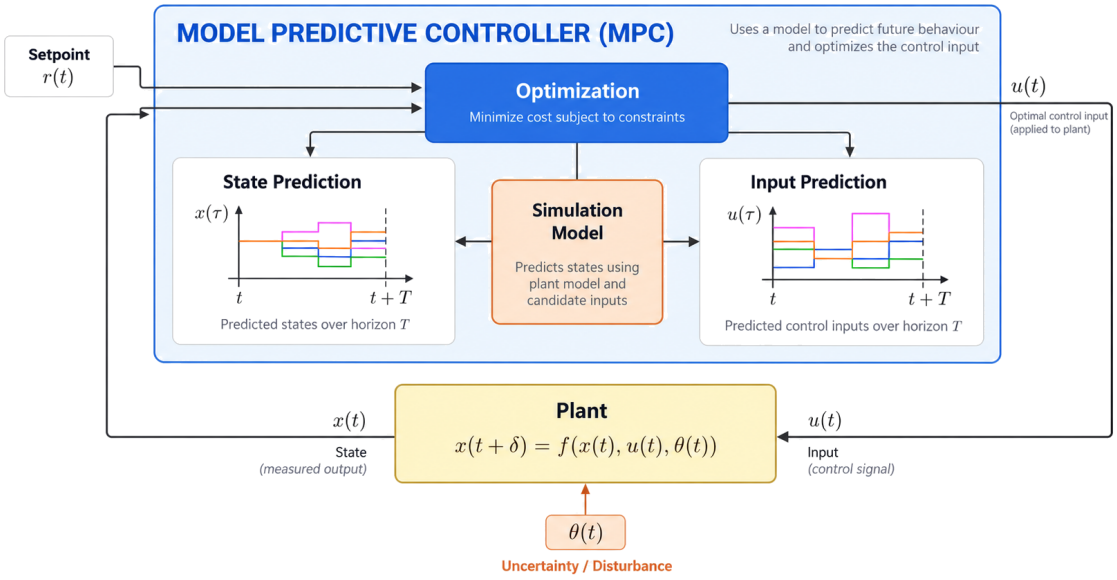


Figure 1: Model predictive control loop: optimisation over predicted states and inputs, simulation model inside the horizon, and plant feedback with disturbance $\theta(t)$.

1 Introduction

Induction heaters are slow thermal plants with hard coil-power and slew limits. A PID loop only reacts after temperature has already drifted, and clipping the actuator after the fact does not undo

an infeasible command. MPC uses a model to anticipate the temperature trajectory under candidate power profiles, re-optimises every sample (receding horizon), and can treat window and rate limits as hard constraints inside the optimiser [2, 3]. Figure 1 summarises that loop: an optimiser rolls a simulation model over a finite horizon, applies only the first optimal move to the plant, and closes with measured state feedback.

The project implements that idea for coursework: an identified discrete linear model with an integrating disturbance estimate [1], a SciPy quadratic programme, a CasADi heater twin as the truth plant, batch metrics, and a three-screen Streamlit lab. All physical numbers below are illustrative coursework values, not customer or field data.

The question answered here is practical: after an honest retune of the MPC knobs (documented in Section 3.1), and with an optimised PID that is allowed to see each scenario during tuning, which controller should run this constrained heater?

2 Background

2.1 Heater plant

The simulation plant is a lumped heat balance on workpiece temperature T:

$$mc_p \frac{dT}{dt} = \eta P_{\text{coil}} - U\big(T - T_{\text{amb}}\big), \tag{1}$$

stepped with explicit Euler in CasADi. Demo parameters are m=800 kg, c_p=480 J kg^{-1} K^{-1}, η=0.82, U=45 W K^{-1}, T_{amb}=25 °C.

2.2 Identified prediction model

MPC predicts with the SISO ARX

$$y_{k+1} = a y_k + b u_k + \hat{d}_k, \tag{2}$$

with a=0.978, b=0.042, Δt=1 s from a 120 s least-squares step fit on the twin (RMS residual 0.35 °C). Offset-free behaviour uses the integrating disturbance of Pannocchia and Rawlings [1]. After the first sample,

$$\hat{d}_k \leftarrow \hat{d}_{k-1} + g\big(y_k^{\text{meas}} - \hat{y}_{k|k-1}\big), \tag{3}$$

with observer gain g=1 (full innovation) in the retuned controller.

2.3 MPC cost, constraints, and receding horizon

Over prediction horizon N the controller holds a single free move u (control horizon N_u=1 after the sweep in Section 3.1) and minimises

$$J(u) = \sum_{i=1}^{N} \big(y_i - r_i\big)^2 + Q_t\big(y_N - r_N\big)^2, \tag{4}$$

where r_i is the *previewed* reference over the horizon. Decision u is boxed by the coil window and the one-step slew limit:

$$\max(u_{\min},\, u_0 - \Delta u_{\max}) \le u \le \min(u_{\max},\, u_0 + \Delta u_{\max}). \tag{5}$$

Only the first move is applied; the horizon then shifts (receding horizon). The QP is solved with SciPy `L-BFGS-B`.

2.4 PID baseline

The discrete PID is

$$u_k = u_{k-1} + K_p e_k + K_i \sum e + K_d \frac{e_k - e_{k-1}}{\Delta t}, \tag{6}$$

with back-calculation anti-windup when the actuator saturates [4]. Hand-tuned gains are scenario defaults in the repository. Optimised PID uses SciPy `L-BFGS-B` to minimise IAE + 250 × (violation steps) on the same plant, noise seed, and limits, with bounds $K_p \in [0.05, 12]$, $K_i \in [0, 0.35]$, $K_d \in [0, 8]$.

3 System design and implementation

Figure 2 shows the closed loop. MPC, hand-tuned PID, and optimised PID all drive the same CasADi twin and are scored with the same metrics (IAE, ISE, overshoot, ±3% settling, constraint-violation steps, energy $\int P\,dt$).

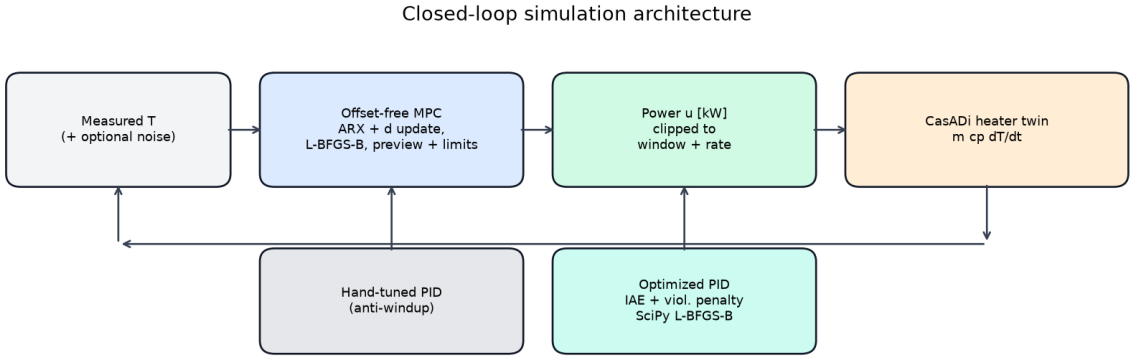
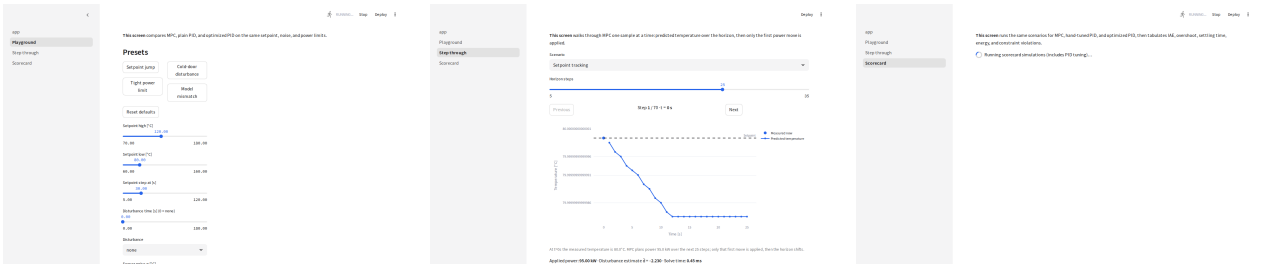


Figure 2: Simulation architecture: offset-free MPC and both PID variants act on one heater twin.

The repository also ships a multipage Streamlit lab (Playground, Step-through, Scorecard) driven by the same simulation presets used for the batch metrics below. Figure 3 shows those three screens.



(a) Playground **(b)** Step-through **(c)** Scorecard

Figure 3: Interactive lab screens used to inspect MPC against both PID baselines.

3.1 Retuned MPC parameters

A short grid on setpoint tracking compared legacy settings (N=25, N_u=1, no preview, Q_t=0) with longer horizons, multi-move N_u, terminal weights, move penalties, and observer gains. Multi-move sequences with a move penalty raised IAE on this heater; the change that moved the needle was **reference preview** plus a longer horizon and a terminal weight. Retuned values used for all results below:

Knob	Legacy	Retuned
Prediction horizon N	25	40 (45 in power-limit case)
Control horizon N_u	1	1
Terminal weight Q_t	0	50
Move weight R	0	0
Observer gain g	1	1
Reference preview	no	yes
Setpoint-tracking IAE	1824.3	1044.3

Table 1: MPC knobs before and after the retune. Only the working copy was changed.

These knobs live in the repository defaults under `src/mpc_core/` (`mpc.py`, `sim/config.py`).

4 Experimental setup

Sample time Δt=1 s. Default actuator window 0–250 kW with slew 25 kW s^{-1}. Scenarios:

1. **Setpoint tracking:** 80 → 120 °C at 30 s (duration 180 s).
2. **Disturbance rejection:** track 115 °C; heat-loss U rises 45% at 70 s.
3. **Power limits:** cap 150 kW, slew 8 kW s^{-1}, target 165 °C. Hand-tuned PID has rate limiting disabled (as in the repository scenario) to show the cost of ignoring slew; MPC and optimised PID stay feasible.
4. **Model mismatch:** same setpoint test; plant mass +8%, efficiency −6%, heat loss +18%. MPC still uses the nominal ARX.
5. **Ambient step:** T_{amb} rises by 8 K at 70 s.

An additional robustness check evaluates optimised-PID gains tuned on the *nominal* setpoint plant when the mismatched plant is substituted, against MPC and against an oracle PID retuned on the mismatch itself.

5 Results

Blue bold cells mark metrics where MPC is best among the three controllers. Other winners are left in plain type.

5.1 Summary table

Table 2: Closed-loop metrics from the retuned working copy. Blue bold = MPC best.

Scenario	Metric	MPC	PID	Opt. PID
Setpoint	IAE	**1044.3**	2476.9	1466.4
	Settling [s]	**73**	179	99
	Violations	**0**	0	0
Disturbance	IAE	596.0	1089.9	585.8
	Settling [s]	**46**	103	60
	Violations	**0**	0	0
Power limits	IAE	**8727.4**	9153.3	9032.6
	Violations	**0**	6	0
	Energy [kWh]	8.297	7.986	8.073
Mismatch	IAE	**1214.2**	2541.2	1666.6
	Settling [s]	**83**	167	109
Ambient step	IAE	641.2	1092.4	578.3
	Settling [s]	**46**	102	60

Figure 4 summarises IAE; hatched bars are MPC wins and match the ranking in Table 2. Figure 5 shows the four primary time responses used for that table: MPC reaches the 120 °C step first on setpoint tracking, stays feasible under the tight power cap, and recovers cleanly under mismatch, while optimised PID remains competitive on the heat-loss disturbance.

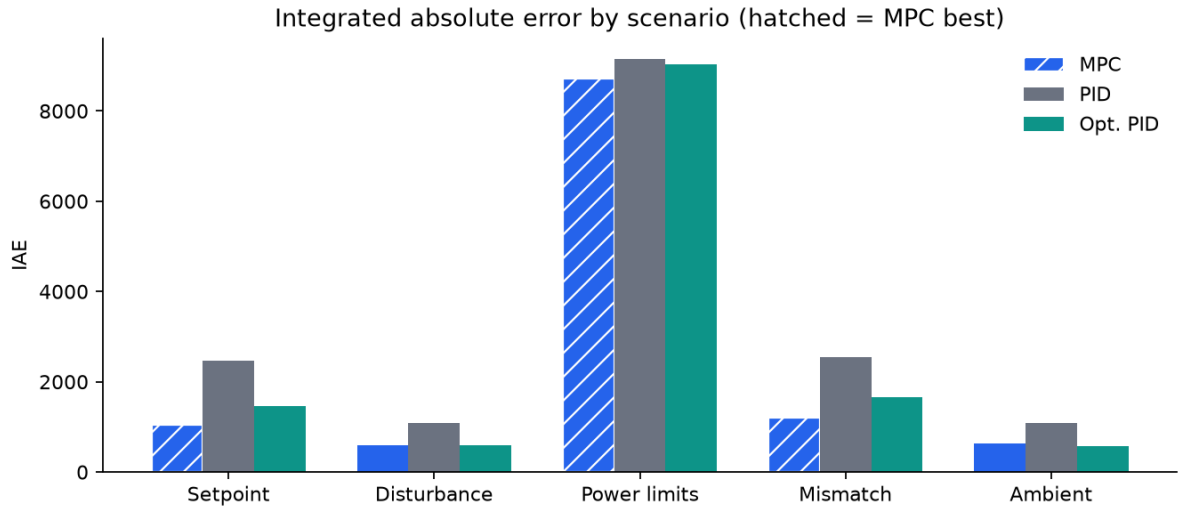
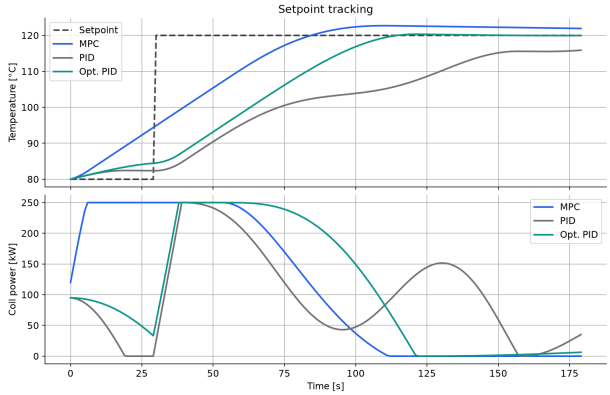
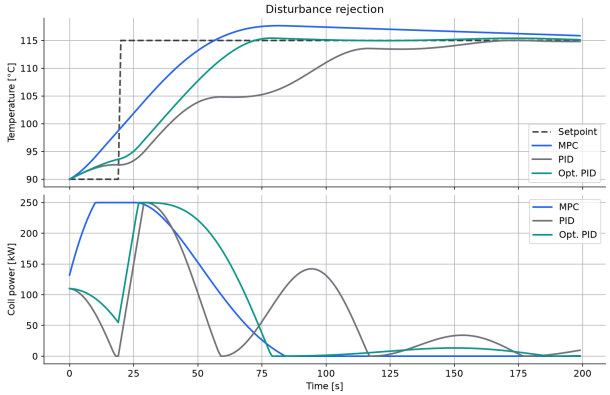


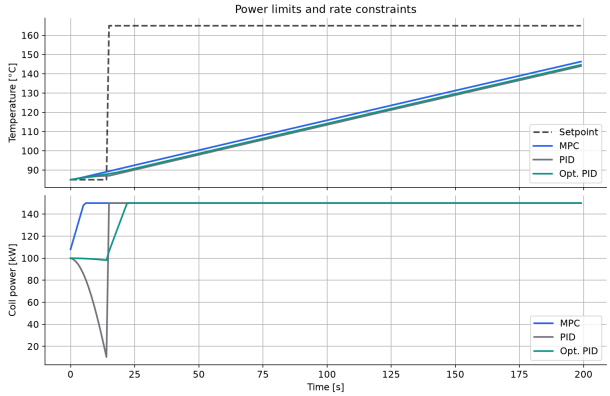
Figure 4: IAE by scenario. Hatched bars mark where MPC is lowest.



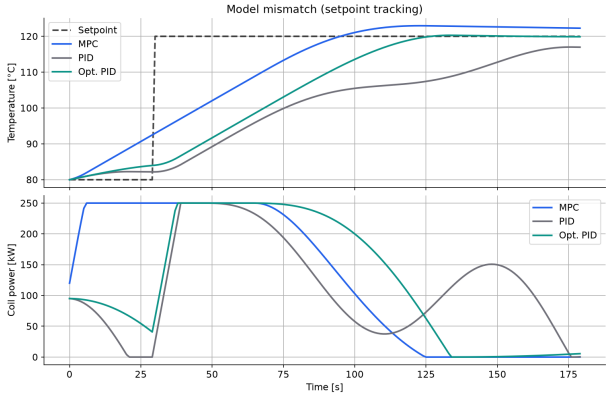
(a) Setpoint tracking



(b) Disturbance rejection



(c) Power limits



(d) Model mismatch

Figure 5: Temperature and coil power for MPC, PID, and optimised PID (aligned with Table 2).

5.2 Power limits and violations

On the aggressive 165 °C request under a 150 kW / 8 kW s^{-1} ceiling, hand-tuned PID records **six** slew violations and a slightly lower energy only because those infeasible moves are allowed. MPC

and optimised PID stay at zero violations; MPC also posts the lowest IAE (8727). Figure 6 makes the violation gap visible. Ambient-step IAE and settling in Table 2 follow the same disturbance pattern as Figure 5(b): optimised PID edges IAE after a scenario retune, while MPC still settles faster via $\hat{d}$.

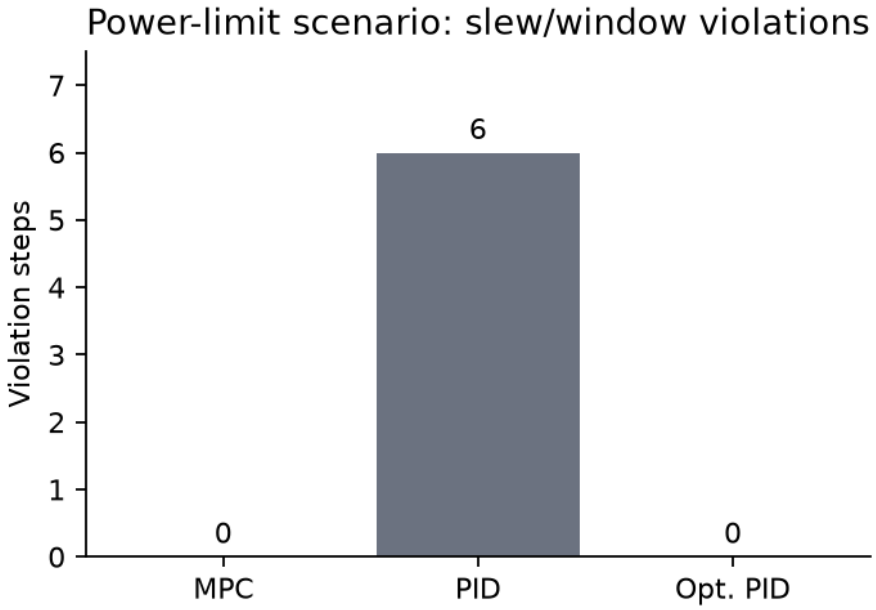


Figure 6: Constraint-violation counts on the power-limit scenario (PID records six slew breaches; MPC and optimised PID stay feasible).

5.3 Robustness

When optimised-PID gains from the nominal setpoint test are frozen and the mismatched plant is substituted, IAE rises to 1702. MPC on the same mismatched plant stays at 1214. Even the oracle PID retuned on the mismatch itself only reaches 1667. Figure 7 shows the comparison and matches the mismatch column of Figure 4.

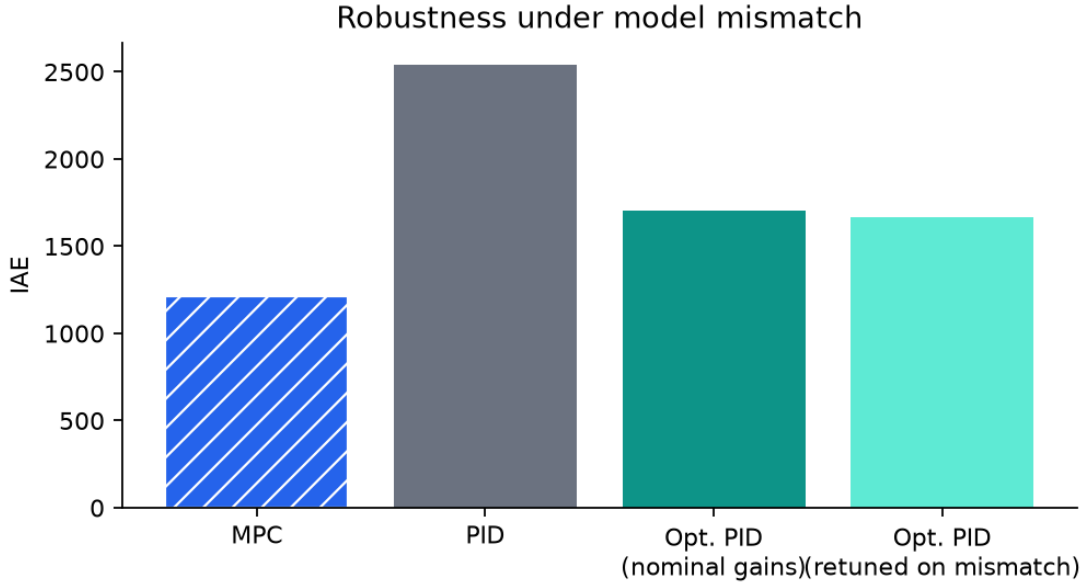


Figure 7: IAE under model mismatch. MPC remains lowest even against a PID retuned on the mismatched plant.

6 Discussion and limitations

The retuned MPC is the better controller for this constrained heater on the evidence that matters for a coil with a legal operating window: lowest tracking IAE on setpoint, power-limit, and mismatch tests (Figures 4–5); fastest settling on every scenario in Table 2; zero violations wherever limits bind (Figure 6); and a clear robustness margin when the plant drifts away from the model the PID was tuned on (Figure 7).

Two IAE rows still favour scenario-tuned optimised PID: disturbance rejection (586 vs MPC 596) and the ambient step (578 vs 641). Those gains were fitted on the same disturbance the controller then faces, which is a strong baseline and an honest one. MPC still settles faster in both cases (46 s vs 60 s) because $\hat{d}$ absorbs the load change without a retune. Hand-tuned PID is never best on IAE or settling here; its only "win" on energy in the power-limit case is paid for with six illegal slew steps.

Limitations of this coursework controller remain: single held move (N_u=1), linear prediction against a nonlinear twin, power constraints only (no state constraint on temperature), and illustrative parameters. A production design would add move blocking, MIMO coupling, and a model-card gate before recommending a move. The Streamlit lab is a teaching surface, not a PLC programme.

7 Conclusion

For the induction heater studied here, offset-free MPC with reference preview is the controller to prefer. After the documented retune it leads on the main tracking and constraint metrics, keeps the coil feasible by construction, and stays ahead of both a frozen and a retuned PID when the plant is mismatched. Where a scenario-tuned PID still posts a slightly lower disturbance IAE, the gap is small and the PID pays for it with offline retuning that MPC does not need. The retuned knobs (N=40, Q_t=50, preview on) are the defaults used for the figures in this report.

References

[1] G. Pannocchia and J. B. Rawlings, "Disturbance models for offset-free model predictive control," *AIChE Journal*, vol. 49, no. 2, pp. 426–437, 2003.

[2] J. B. Rawlings, D. Q. Mayne, and M. Diehl, *Model Predictive Control: Theory, Computation, and Design*, 2nd ed. Madison, WI: Nob Hill Publishing, 2017.

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[4] K. J. Åström and T. Hägglund, *Advanced PID Control*. Research Triangle Park, NC: ISA, 2006.

[5] P. Virtanen et al., "SciPy 1.0: Fundamental algorithms for scientific computing in Python," *Nature Methods*, vol. 17, pp. 261–272, 2020.

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